

He was within 0.2 points of the Chinese shooter at one stage, literally a fingernail's width if measured on the target. But a single weak shot of 9.8 towards the endgame gave Lihao the lead, which he wouldn't forfeit until the finish.

For his part, Himanshu gamely fought on until the end, shooting a 10.8 (as close to perfect without being perfect) in his final shot of the competition against the Chinese machine's 10.6.

Harder than it looks

After he walked out of the finals hall exhausted, Himanshu allowed himself to crack a grin. He had two Asian Games medals clinking against each other around his neck, after all, having once decided he would become a shooter because he thought it would be easy.

"Mujhe laga tha wrestling se toh behtar hoga [I thought it would definitely be better than wrestling]," he

had once told *Sportstar*.

Growing up in the village of Dauhla in Haryana's Jind, Himanshu was originally supposed to be a wrestler. There was precedent in his family. Himanshu's uncle is Hardeep Singh Dhillon, a two-time Asian Wrestling Championships medallist, who represented India in the 98kg

Greco-Roman category at the 2016 Rio Olympics and in the 97kg category at the 2018 Asian Games.

When Himanshu was 13, he was packed off to a residential *gurukul* (school) to perhaps train as a wrestler or at the very least get a bit active. "I was really *sust* (lazy). So my parents thought it would help me gain a little independence," he recalls. Introduced to wrestling, though, he soon realised he wanted very little to do with it.

"The first day I trained as a wrestler, I got so many aches and pains. I decided right then that I needed to find something where I wasn't going to get injured," he remembers thinking. As luck would have it, the

